In popular parlance, Hanuman is synonymous with devotion, perseverance and strength. The irony, of course, is that Hanuman himself does not know the full extent of his own powers. As Agastya revealed to Rama, this was the result of his antics in early youth that troubled many sages in the midst of their meditation. Hanuman was, therefore, cursed to be forgetful until divine duties require otherwise. As the epic unfolds and Hanuman takes on increasing responsibilities, his own self-awareness enhances commensurately. At key junctures, he is indeed the saviour of the situation. When Sita was abducted and a search mission was set into motion, Sugriva divided his army and sent them in all four directions under experienced leaders. Vinata, Sushena and Shatabali were tasked with leading the forces to the east, west and north respectively. But it was Hanuman, along with Angada, who was given the responsibility of going south, which was perceived as the most promising prospect. Just as Angada was giving up on the task, Hanuman exhorted him to keep faith and persevere.

As he stepped forward during various stages of the epic, his true potential was displayed for the world to see. When Lakshmana was struck down in battle and could only be revived by the medicinal plant *Vishalyakarani*, Hanuman was sent to the Dronagiri Mountain to gather it. Unable to identify the plant specifically in day time, he picked up the entire mountain and brought it for the more discerning monkey-chieftain Sushena to pick the right herb. As many other occasions testify, Hanuman is determined, innovative, outcome-oriented and self-confident.

The legend of Hanuman could well be the story of India in the last decade. The more we do, the more we believe we can do. It is this self-discovery that has made India so different in recent years and set it on a course that has major implications for the global order.

A DEMOCRACY THAT DELIVERS

India can matter by just being there, as a market place, as a contested ground, a resource or a platform. Indeed, as it did during colonial times. This breeds a survival mentality that, at best, can graduate to a transactional one. But India can also matter through the power of its ideas and actions as an engine of the global economy, a hub of innovation or a democracy that delivers. That is the course of destiny, and its ambitious path requires deep determination and strong perseverance. The debates within our society will decide which road is finally taken. As a nation, choices are becoming increasingly stark. The progress of the last decade points to hope and optimism, while the old order highlights our insecurities and underlines the divides.